



Sort Array

Given an integer array, **sort the array** in ascending order.

Example:

Input: `nums = [6, 8, 4, 2, 7, 3, 1, 5]`

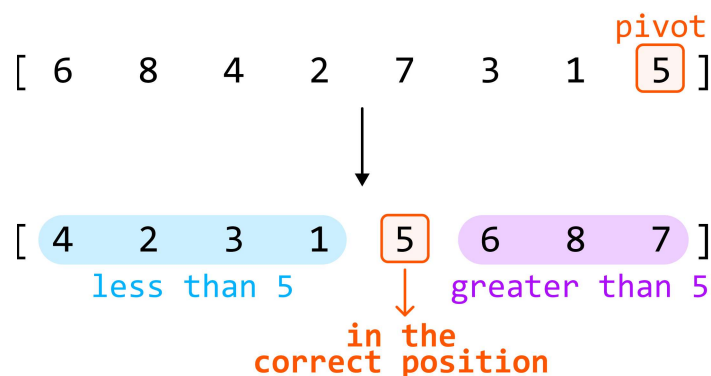
Output: `[1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8]`

Intuition

This problem is quite open-ended because there are many sorting algorithms we could use to sort an array, each with its own pros and cons. In this explanation, we focus on the quicksort algorithm, which runs in $O(n \log(n))$ time on average, where n denotes the length of the array.

Quicksort

Conceptually, the goal of quicksort is to sort the array by **placing each number in its sorted position one at a time**. To correctly position a number, we move all numbers smaller than it to its left, and all numbers larger than it to its right. At each step, we call this number the pivot. We discuss how a pivot is selected later in the explanation.



This process is called **partitioning** because we're dividing the array into two parts around the pivot:

1. The left part with elements smaller than the pivot.
2. The right part with elements larger than the pivot.

Note that neither the left nor the right part of the pivot value need to be sorted. All that matters is that the pivot is in the correct position.

this is provided below:

```
def quicksort(nums, left, right):
    # Partition the array and obtain the index of the pivot.
    pivot_index = partition(nums, left, right)
    # Sort the left and right parts.
    quicksort(nums, left, pivot_index - 1)
    quicksort(nums, pivot_index + 1, right)
```

Let's discuss the partitioning process in more detail.

Partitioning

There are two primary steps to partitioning:

1. Selecting the pivot.
2. Rearranging the elements so elements smaller than the pivot are on its left, and elements larger than the pivot are on its right.

Selecting the pivot

We can actually choose any number as the pivot. The method of selecting a pivot can be optimized, which is discussed later, but for simplicity, we can choose the rightmost number as the pivot:

								pivot
	6	8	4	2	7	3	1	5
	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7

Rearranging elements around the pivot

Let's see if we can do this in linear time without using extra space.

If we can ensure all numbers less than the pivot are placed to the left, then numbers greater than or equal to the pivot will consequently be placed to the right. This can be done using two pointers:

- One pointer at the left of the array (**lo**) to position the numbers less than the pivot.
- One pointer to iterate through the array (**i**), looking for numbers less than the pivot.

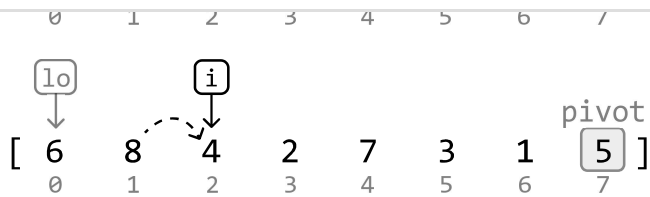
The main idea here is that whenever we encounter a number less than the pivot, swap it with `nums[lo]`.

Let's look at the example below to understand how this works. First, keep advancing **i** until we find a number less than the pivot:

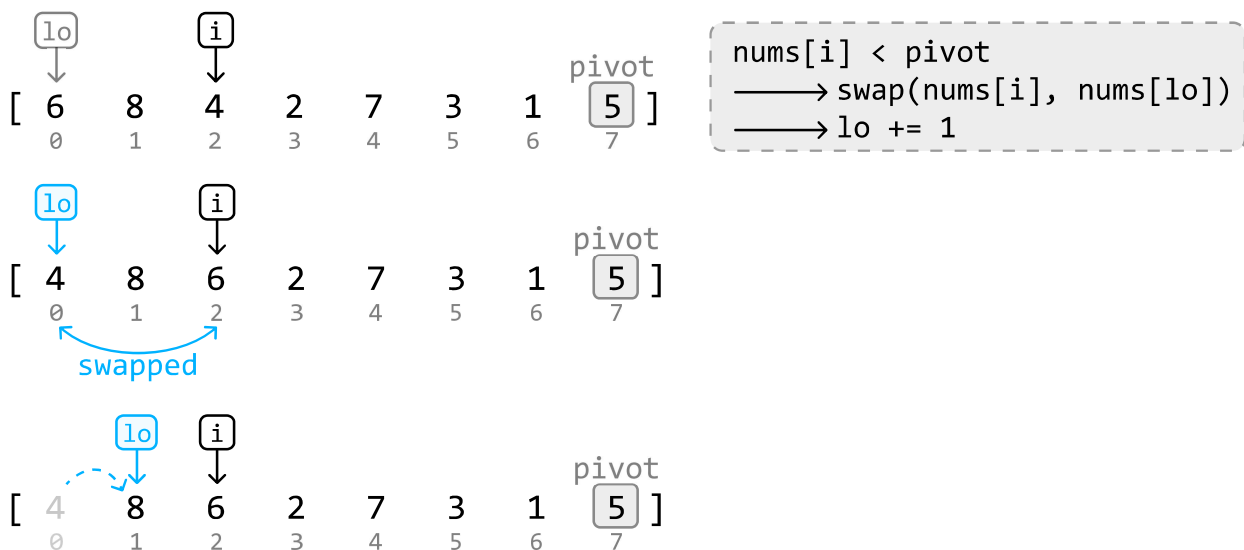
lo	i							
6	8	4	2	7	3	1	5	
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	

pivot

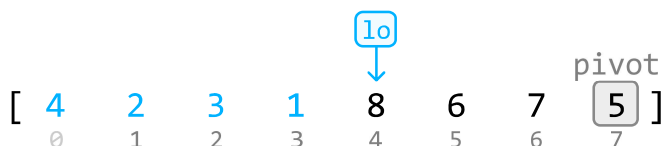
`nums[i] > pivot`
 $\longrightarrow$ continue



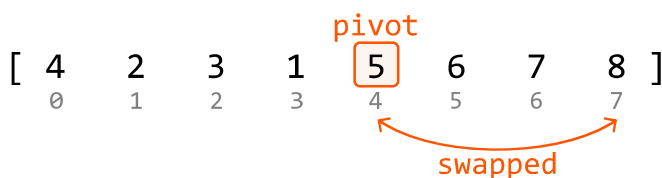
Once a number less than the pivot is found, move it to the left by swapping it with `nums[lo]`. Then, increment `lo` so it points to where the next number less than the pivot should be placed:



Continue this process until all numbers less than the pivot are on the left of the array:



The last step is to move the pivot to the correct position by swapping the pivot with `nums[lo]`:



Implementation

Python

JavaScript

Java

```
from typing import List
```



```
def quicksort(nums: List[int], left: int, right: int) → None:
    # Base case: if the subarray has 0 or 1 element, it's already sorted.
    if left ≥ right:
        return
    # Partition the array and retrieve the pivot index.
    pivot_index = partition(nums, left, right)
    # Call quicksort on the left and right parts to recursively sort them.
    quicksort(nums, left, pivot_index - 1)
    quicksort(nums, pivot_index + 1, right)

def partition(nums: List[int], left: int, right: int) → int:
    pivot = nums[right]
    lo = left
    # Move all numbers less than the pivot to the left, which consequently position
    # all numbers greater than or equal to the pivot to the right.
    for i in range(left, right):
        if nums[i] < pivot:
            nums[lo], nums[i] = nums[i], nums[lo]
            lo += 1
    # After partitioning, 'lo' will be positioned where the pivot should be. So,
    # the pivot number with the number at the 'lo' pointer.
    nums[lo], nums[right] = nums[right], nums[lo]
    return lo
```

Complexity Analysis

Time complexity: The time complexity of `sort_array` can be analyzed in terms of the average and worst cases:

- Average case: $O(n \log(n))$. In the average case, quicksort effectively divides the array into two roughly equal parts after each partition, leading to a recursive tree with a depth of approximately $\log_2(n)$. For each of these levels, we perform a partition which takes $O(n)$ time, resulting in a total time complexity of $O(n \log(n))$.
- Worst case: $O(n^2)$. The worst-case scenario occurs when the pivot selection consistently results in extremely unbalanced partitions, such as when the smallest or largest element is always chosen as a pivot, which is explained in more detail in the optimization. Uneven partitioning can result in a recursive depth as deep as n . For each of these n levels of recursion, we perform a partition which takes $O(n)$ time, resulting in a total time complexity of $O(n^2)$.


```

    return

    # Choose a pivot at a random index.
    random_index = random.randint(left, right)
    # Swap the randomly chosen pivot with the rightmost element to position the p
    # at the rightmost index.
    nums[random_index], nums[right] = nums[right], nums[random_index]
    pivot_index = partition(nums, left, right)
    quicksort_optimized(nums, left, pivot_index - 1)
    quicksort_optimized(nums, pivot_index + 1, right)

```

Interview Follow-Up

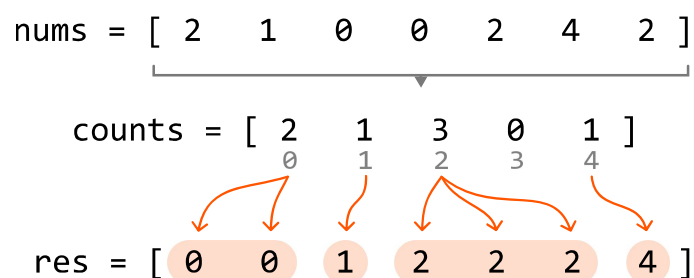
Let's say the interviewer introduces the following constraints to the initial sorting problem:

- The input array does not contain negative values.
- All values in the input array are less than or equal to 10^3 .

Does our approach to the problem change, and should we still use quicksort? Considering that all values in our array now fall within the limited range of $[0, 10^3]$, a counting sort approach becomes appropriate.

Counting sort

Counting sort is a non-comparison-based sorting algorithm that works by counting the number of occurrences of each element in the array, then using these counts to place each element in its correct sorted position:



We can do this in two steps:

1. Count occurrences: create a counts array, where each of its indexes represents an element from the original array. Increment the value at each index based on how many times the corresponding element appears in the original array.
2. Build sorted array (**res**): iterate through each index of the counts array and add that index (**i**) to the sorted array as many times as its value (**counts[i]**) indicates.

constraint is not specified and the maximum value in the array may be very large, then a counting sort solution might not be appropriate, due to the potentially large size of the counts array.

Implementation

Note that there's another common method for implementing counting sort, which is detailed in the reference provided [2].

```
Python JavaScript Java

from typing import List

def sort_array_counting_sort(nums: List[int]) → List[int]:
    if not nums:
        return []
    res = []
    # Count occurrences of each element in 'nums'.
    counts = [0] * (max(nums) + 1)
    for num in nums:
        counts[num] += 1
    # Build the sorted array by appending each index 'i' to it a total of 'counts[i]'
    # times.
    for i, count in enumerate(counts):
        res.extend([i] * count)
    return res
```

Complexity Analysis

Time complexity: The time complexity of `sort_array_counting_sort` is $O(n + k)$, where k denotes the maximum value of `nums`. This is because it takes $O(n)$ time to count the occurrences of each element and $O(k)$ time to build the sorted array.

Space complexity: The space complexity is $O(n + k)$, since the `res` array occupies $O(n)$ space, and the counts array takes up $O(k)$ space. Note that `res` is considered in the space complexity, as counting sort is not an in-place sorting algorithm requiring an additional array to store the sorted result.

Interview Tip

Tip: Quicksort is useful for in-place sorting.

While quicksort isn't a stable sorting algorithm, it is an in-place sorting algorithm, meaning it requires less additional space compared to an algorithm such as merge sort, which takes $O(n)$ space when used to sort an array.



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